

TSANGAI BUSINESS GROWTH SERIES · #14

The Email Playbook

Cut your inbox time in half with two daily windows, a four-letter triage system, and AI drafting the replies you send most.

WHO IT'S FOR

Owners who open email "for a minute" and surface 90 minutes later

TIME REQUIRED

15 minutes

WHAT YOU'LL ACHIEVE

A triage system installed and your top 3 reply templates built today

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Your inbox is other people's to-do list for you. Stop living in it.

Two scheduled email windows a day. Four possible moves per email. AI drafts for everything repetitive. That's the whole playbook — and it reliably halves inbox time in the first week.

Email feels like work because it moves — but answering messages all day is being a receptionist for your own company. The owners I work with don't get less email after this playbook. They just spend half the time on it, because every message gets one of four moves and AI writes the first draft of most replies.

— Ray, TsangAI Consulting

WHY THIS MATTERS

2–3 hrs

Daily time many owners spend in email, mostly re-reading the same messages

23 min

Roughly what each "quick email check" costs once you count the refocus time

80%

Of your replies follow patterns AI can draft in seconds

THE ONE IDEA

Touch it once: Delete, Delegate, Draft, or Do.

Every email gets exactly one move the moment you read it. Delete it, delegate it, have AI draft the reply, or do it now if it takes under two minutes. Re-reading is the silent killer — one touch, one decision, next message.

Example: A renovation contractor checked email between every task — 40+ opens a day. New system: 9am and 3pm windows, four-move triage, AI drafts for quotes and scheduling. Inbox time went from 2.5 hours to under one, and clients said he got MORE responsive, because replies now come in predictable windows.

YOUR 10-MINUTE QUICK WIN

- ☐ Book two 30-minute email windows in your calendar (morning + afternoon)
- ☐ Turn off email notifications on your phone — the windows replace them
- ☐ Set up the AI Reply Assistant prompt from page 4
- ☐ Triage today's inbox with the four moves — touch each email once

Five steps to inbox control

1 Schedule your two windows

Email happens at 9am and 3pm (or whatever fits your trade), 30 minutes each. Outside the windows, the inbox stays closed. Urgent things find your phone — that's what it's for.

Do this: Add both blocks as recurring calendar events. Turn off email notifications everywhere.

2 Run the four-move triage

Newest to oldest, one move per email: Delete (or archive), Delegate (forward with one line), Draft (send to AI), or Do (under 2 minutes = handle now).

Do this: Print the cheat sheet on page 4 or keep it open during your first three windows.

3 Set up your AI Reply Assistant

One saved prompt that knows your business and tone. Paste any email in; get a send-ready draft out. Review, tweak one line, send.

Do this: Copy the Reply Assistant prompt from page 4 into a saved note or custom instruction.

4 Template your top three repeats

Look at your sent folder: the same three replies are everywhere — pricing questions, scheduling, "here's what happens next." Make them one-click templates.

Do this: Build 3 templates from page 4's starters. Save as Gmail templates or snippets.

5 Cut the inflow at the source

Less email in, less email to manage. Unsubscribe ruthlessly, filter notifications past the inbox, and answer your five most-asked questions on your website so they stop arriving as email.

Do this: In your next window, unsubscribe from 10 lists and create 2 filters. Repeat weekly until quiet.

COMMON MISTAKES

This is where most business owners get stuck.

They keep notifications on "just in case" — which makes every sender the boss of their attention. They read emails twice, deciding nothing the first time. And they use AI for one-off replies but never template the messages they send every single day.

PRO TIP

Add one line to your email signature: "For fastest scheduling, book directly here: [your booking link]." It quietly deletes an entire category of back-and-forth — the "what times work for you?" thread — forever.

The triage card, the assistant, the templates

The 4-Move Triage Card

MOVE	WHEN
Delete	No action needed — archive and move on
Delegate	Someone else's call — forward with one line
Draft	Needs a real reply — paste into AI, edit, send
Do	Under 2 minutes — handle it right now

The AI Reply Assistant

You are my email assistant at [BUSINESS NAME], a [WHAT YOU DO] business in [AREA]. Tone: friendly, brief, professional. When I paste an email, reply with a send-ready draft that: answers directly, offers the next step ([BOOKING LINK / QUOTE / CALL]), and stays under 120 words. If key info is missing, ask me one question instead of guessing. Email: [PASTE]

Template 1 · Pricing question

Hi [NAME] — great question. For [SERVICE], most jobs land between [RANGE], depending on [KEY FACTOR]. The fastest way to get your exact number: [BOOKING LINK / SITE VISIT]. Takes [TIME].

Template 2 · Scheduling

Hi [NAME] — happy to get you booked. Grab any time that suits you here: [BOOKING LINK]. If none work, reply with two windows and I'll make one fit.

Template 3 · What happens next

Hi [NAME] — you're all set. Next steps: 1) [STEP] by [DATE], 2) [STEP], 3) [STEP]. I'll confirm each as it happens — nothing needed from you until [DATE].

Turn this guide into one win this week.

A guide you read changes nothing. A page you fill in does. Two minutes — do it while it's fresh.

1 • WHERE I AM TODAY

My email windows: _____ & _____ Templates saved: _____ / 3

2 • THE ONE THING I'M FIXING THIS WEEK

My one fix: _____

The first small step (under 15 minutes): _____

Small beats big. Pick something you can finish in one sitting.

3 • WHEN I'M DOING IT

Day: _____ Time: _____ Booked in my calendar? ☐

Open your calendar and book it now — a plan without a time slot is a wish.

4 • AFTER — WHAT HAPPENED

My result (hours saved, jobs booked, thing shipped): _____

What I'll do differently next time: _____

NOTES

KEEP THE STREAK

One fix a week is 52 upgrades a year. When this page is full, re-take the guide — a rising score is proof your systems are working.